A PASTOR CAN BE KNOWN AND STILL UNSUPPORTED.

People can know your name, hear your sermons, and depend on your leadership without knowing what you carry.

Visibility can hide isolation. Recognition and support are not the same. A Pastor may be surrounded by people, appreciated by the church, and still have no safe place to speak honestly or share the weight.

The figures on the companion visual offer both recognition and a question. To the Pastor who feels alone: **you are not the only one.** To the church: do we know the person, or only depend on the role?

Who knows the soul beneath your role?

The stronger and more capable the Pastor, the longer an unhealthy imbalance can hide. The Pastor keeps stepping in, people grow accustomed to it, and what began as faithfulness quietly becomes the way everything stays afloat.

Jesus named His sorrow

In Gethsemane, no one could carry the cup for Jesus. Yet He named His sorrow, brought Peter, James, and John closer, and asked them to keep watch while He prayed. They fell asleep. Their failure did not make His honesty weakness or His request a mistake. Jesus remained faithful to the Father even when human support failed.

MARK 14:32-42

Jesus shows us that honest sorrow and faithful obedience are not opposites.

Privacy uses wise boundaries. Isolation leaves no one close enough to pray, tell the truth, or recognize danger. A Pastor does not owe everyone full access. But every Pastor needs trustworthy, godly people who know what is true and have permission to comfort, question, and challenge in love.

These relationships must become places of shared prayer, not only places to talk. Together we come before the Father, listen to Jesus through His Word, and ask the Holy Spirit to reveal what is true, bring comfort and conviction, and lead us into faithful action. We can make room for change; only God can bring real life change.

> **“Therefore, a Christian needs another Christian who speaks God’s Word to him.”**
>
> **Dietrich Bonhoeffer | Life Together**

Support changes what someone carries

Joshua fought. Aaron and Hur held Moses steady. God gave the victory. Different people carried different parts, and no one person was the whole work.

EXODUS 17:8-13

The Philippians did more than appreciate Paul. They shared his trouble, sent help more than once, and sent people to care for his needs. Their support cost them something, and Paul let them share the weight. Care was not a sentiment: they stayed close, gave generously, and acted.

PHILIPPIANS 2:25-30; 4:14-18

Support changes what someone carries.

Pastor, your strength may have protected the church for a season. It cannot become the church's plan.

Church, gratitude is not support if our expectations remain unchanged.

Not every weight belongs on the Pastor's shoulders simply because they have been willing to carry it.

Questions worth sitting with

1. Where do we need to seek God together - and keep seeking Him - as we tell the truth and act?
2. Where have we benefited from the Pastor carrying what others should have been prepared or authorized to carry? What has become normal here that is not sustainable?
3. What will we stop, fund, share, or delay in the next 30 days so the Pastor has measurably less to carry?

Putting this into practice

Begin in prayer and tell the truth. Ask the Pastor what would help, but do not hand the work of building support back to the Pastor. Name what others can carry, give them the authority and resources to carry it, and follow through. Keep praying as you act. Then return and ask whether the care is actually helping.

Support may include protected rest, pulpit coverage, a changed schedule, peer support, confidential counseling or spiritual direction chosen by the Pastor, ending needless work, or placing responsibility into capable hands.

We cannot manufacture real life change. God does that work. But we can repent, remove unnecessary weight, keep our commitments, and make room for health.

Moving into the next chapter

The goal is not to diminish the Pastor's calling. It is to let the whole body mature - and to make ministry sustainable enough that no one has to break for the church to keep going.

That brings us to Who Are You Bringing With You?

Leading the conversation

Before

- Place the pastoral-support visual immediately before this read sheet. Its figures come from separate Barna survey questions. They are not a scale, progression, or mathematical contrast.
- Meet privately with the Pastor first. Explain who will participate, how information will be used, and what will remain confidential. Let the Pastor decide what personal information may be shared.
- Pray with the Pastor and staff before the evaluation begins. Come before the Father, listen to Jesus through His Word, and ask the Holy Spirit to lead.

During

- Do not begin by asking the Pastor to explain what is wrong. Begin by asking governing leaders what the church has placed on the role and what they are prepared to change.
- Keep the conversation from becoming another assignment for the Pastor. The board, staff, volunteers, and congregation should ask what part Christ is calling them to carry.
- Return to prayer when difficult truths surface. Do not use prayer to rush disclosure, silence disagreement, or avoid necessary action.
- Do not pressure a Pastor to disclose pain publicly. Privacy is not isolation, and transparency does not mean telling everything to everyone. Trusted support is chosen, confidential, godly, and able to offer both comfort and honest challenge.
- Do not cast the Pastor as Jesus or the board and congregation as the disciples who fell asleep. Christ's work is unique. The passage shows that honest sorrow, prayer, and faithful obedience can remain together.

After

- Agree on one concrete change, who will carry it, what authority or resources they need, and when the group will return to ask whether the care is helping.
- Do not use personal disclosures as leverage in performance reviews, compensation decisions, conflict, or gossip. Where trust is broken or employment power is present, consider a neutral or external facilitator.
- Honor the Pastor's faithfulness without making overwork untouchable. A willingness to carry weight does not prove that the weight still belongs on the Pastor's shoulders.
- Keep praying as the church acts. Human support cannot do God's work, but the body of Christ must not leave a shepherd unseen and alone while God does it.

Prayer prompts

Before: Father, help us see what is true without hiding or accusing. Jesus, speak through Your Word and through the people You have placed around us. Holy Spirit, lead us.

When hard truth surfaces: Jesus, keep us honest, humble, and kind. Show us what obedience requires.

Before action: Holy Spirit, show each of us what to carry, what to release, and how to follow through.

Scripture and sources

Scripture and content boundaries

- **Mark 14:32-42:** Jesus named His sorrow, asked Peter, James, and John to keep watch, and prayed in submission to the Father. No one could carry the cup for Him. Do not compare a Pastor's calling with Christ's unique work.
- **John 16:13-15:** Jesus teaches that the Spirit of truth guides and glorifies Him. Dependence on the Holy Spirit should keep the process centered on Christ rather than the group's opinions.
- **Exodus 17:8-13:** Joshua fought, Aaron and Hur held Moses steady, and God gave the victory. Different people carried different parts; the passage must not place Moses or a modern Pastor beyond accountability.
- **Philippians 2:25-30; 4:14-18:** The Philippian church shared in Paul's troubles, sent help more than once, and sent someone to care for his needs.
- **1 Thessalonians 5:11-14; Galatians 6:2:** These passages ground mutual encouragement, help for the weak, patience, and shared burdens. Read the passages from a Bible rather than presenting our application as a quotation from Scripture.

Supporting quotation

“When we struggle privately, we compensate in the way we lead.”

Andy Stanley | Courage in Leadership

Use this quotation only to explain why safe support matters. Never use it to diagnose the Pastor, question fitness for ministry, or demand disclosure.

Sources

- Barna Group. “7-Year Trends: Pastors Feel More Loneliness & Less Support.” July 12, 2023. Companion visual figures: 2022 survey of 585 U.S. Protestant senior Pastors.
- Bonhoeffer, Dietrich. Life Together. Hymns Ancient and Modern Ltd., 2012 Kindle edition, locations 116-121.
- Stanley, Andy. “From the Vault: Courage in Leadership.” Andy Stanley Leadership Podcast, August 2023.

Prayer before the next step

> **Father, show us what is true. Jesus, keep us close to You and to one another. Holy Spirit, lead us into the change that obedience requires. Give us courage to share the weight and faithfulness to keep our commitments. Amen.**